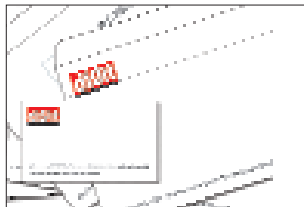


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Digital Business

How Technology Can Help Your Organisation

Smart Business

The Customer is King

It's already widely accepted that Customer Relationship Management (CRM) can boost your business significantly, not to mention make your customers happy—what if you could implement it for your company at little or no cost?

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Consider this: you've called up, say, your mobile service provider to resolve an issue you're having with your connection. Once it's been addressed, the customer service executive informs you of a special offer on tariffs—you think, "Ah! This fits perfectly with my usage", and accept the offer. You disconnect, satisfied and impressed. No coincidence, this—if you've ever been satisfied with customer service, it's because your service provider is using a Customer Relationship Management (CRM) solution that gives them all the information they need to know what will make you happy.

What And Why

CRM solutions let you do just that—manage your relationships with customers—making sure that service requests are responded to in a timely manner, for instance. For you as a businessperson, it means that all your customer information is consolidated in one database, making it easier for you to identify opportunities for further sales. Like the example above, a CRM solution will let you track all your customers' history, so when you start a new sales campaign, you'll know which customers are likely to buy your product. You'll get your income, and your customer will walk away satisfied, which will eventually translate into even more income. Everybody wins.

Indirectly, you'll even be able to better your products (or services, as the case may be). For example, if your customers are having trouble with a certain feature in your product, you can use this information to amend the product's manual, or even change the product itself.

Before you decide to opt for a CRM solution, however, you should ask yourself whether you really need it. If you handle a lot of repeat business, then you'll benefit tremendously from a CRM solution—especially if your sales force isn't the size of a battalion. Even a small travel agency, for example, may have a few thousand loyal customers without having more than ten employees. With a CRM solution, the agency can track feedback on customers' trips, their suggestions, their travel patterns, and based on all that information, keep them informed of special packages that they're most likely to purchase. By targeting the right customers for a package, salespeople won't waste their time listening to the dreaded "Not interested". In fact, they'll be able to handle even more customers with the same effort!

If, on the other hand, you're always trying to snag new customers, and your existing customer database is for reference only, a contact management solution will work, and won't be as much of a headache to manage as a full-blown CRM system.

CRM solutions are typically big investments, but the cost of "commercial" open source software is significantly lower than a